

whether it is a Windows PC or a non-Windows PC. What we are leveraging in Windows 8 is just features and innovations that are coming up at the hardware level. I don't see a problem there because I know for a fact that there will be co-existence eventually, because this is a hardware innovation. It is just like how every product has to adapt to something or the other. There will always be features that may seem like blocking initially, but technology doesn't remain stationary and adaptation is required of everybody—whether it is Windows, Linux or different distributions of Linux. Infact we've already seen SUSE and other distributions adapt to the secure boot feature in UEFI.

Q Microsoft has joined hands with the state government in Tamil Nadu. As soon as Microsoft signed the agreement, the Tamil Nadu government changed its stance of using 'only' open source in the free laptops it gave students as soon as it inked a pact with the company. The students had to switch over to Windows, abandoning BOSS Linux, which generated ire from the community. The government finally settled for providing the dual-boot option rather than just BOSS or only Windows. Don't you think such efforts are a threat for the community?

See, I cannot comment on the political aspect of things. But I see it as a positive, because when the student graduates and is looking for employment, the student would have both options. Let's be honest—if they had gone for just Linux, it would have been a loss of opportunity for Microsoft, just like when we win something, it is a loss of opportunity for Linux. Every vendor, whether it is for Windows or for Linux, is going to capitalise on the growth and opportunities that India offers. So, at the end of the day, there will be times when X will win and times when Y will win. Regarding the particular case you mentioned, I think it is a perfect situation because as a student, I will get access to both. There is no cost issue involved here.

Going back to the fundamental issue, I would re-assert that there is nothing that is free (monetarily). Whether a government adopts a proprietary platform or an open source platform, there is a cost involved. That might be the upfront purchase cost or the cost of implementation, maintenance, etc. But there will be a cost. There are enough research studies today that mention companies saying that you cannot look at acquisition as the only cost. When you think about software and technology, you have to think about the longer term and the total cost of ownership, which includes not just the acquisition cost but things like implementation, deployment, maintenance, downtime, the security impact and all of that. So I think your point that proprietary software is more expensive and open source is less expensive, or free, is not true. Otherwise, there wouldn't be a commercial distribution of any open source software. Take any open source software company. They will have two versions of their software—one is the open source version and the other is the commercial version. Have you seen any company

providing implementation, consulting and deployment support for free? Not really. Everybody has to make money.

For Microsoft, we openly say that we are a proprietary software company in a majority of the things that we do and here is how much our software will cost. Open source software is slightly different. Those companies say that if people use their commercial software, they need to buy a subscription and that comes at a cost. I think what has happened in Tamil Nadu is great actually. Today, the student gets both Windows as well as Linux. What could be better for a student! Ultimately I think the Tamil Nadu government would have taken a decision based on what it thought was right and what was in the best interests of the students. I think it's time that we moved ahead of the debate about which one is better—open source or proprietary technologies. I think the need of the hour is that both proprietary and open source technologies join hands. So, if students get laptops with both software, they get exposure and choice and we should let them have it. This will help in increasing their employability. The focus should be on building capabilities as opposed to discussions on technology.

Microsoft is committed to openness. Microsoft is becoming more open in the way that we work with and collaborate with others in the industry, in how we listen to customers, and in our approach to the cloud. While this subsidiary has been formed in the US, the existing openness initiatives and those going forward through this subsidiary will definitely benefit customers, developers and the open source ecosystem globally, including those in India.

Q What about Codeplex? It has over 28,000 projects. Are there projects that open source developers can make money from?

Absolutely! It would be very difficult for me to say who is making the money, or how much. I would like to use the example of Sugar CRM. The way they are making money is phenomenal. So I think it's not about Source Forge or CodePlex, it's about the developer having an idea, and willing to invest that amount of time and effort in turning that idea into a viable business proposition. 

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